de Basanti (roughly translates as ‘The Colour of Sacrifice’). Then, when the music stopped, the mob disappeared into the crowd. In any other country this would have been considered sacrilege but in India it was widely seen as appropriate. The whole episode was filmed and became an instant hit on the Internet. But, why do Indians remember a horrible event by dancing?

The key to resolving the paradox is to realize that Indians view history not in political but in civilizational terms. When Americans raise their flag at the 9/11 sites, they reaffirm the resilience of their nation state. When Indians dance at the site of the 26/11 massacre, they celebrate the triumph of their civilization.

The history of India’s geography and civilization reminds us of the insignificance of each generation in the vastness of time. The greatest of India’s monarchs and thinkers too felt it. So they left behind their stories and thoughts in ballads, folk-tales, epics and inscriptions. Even if these memories are not always literally true, what matters is that they carry on the essence of India’s civilization. On the island of Mauritius, descendants of Indian immigrants have transferred their memories of the river Ganga to a lake, Ganga Talao, that they now hold as sacred. A very long time ago, their distant ancestors would have similarly transferred the memory of the Saraswati to the Ganga. Geography is not just about the physical terrain, but also about the meaning that we attribute to it. Thus, the Saraswati flows, invisibly, at Allahabad.